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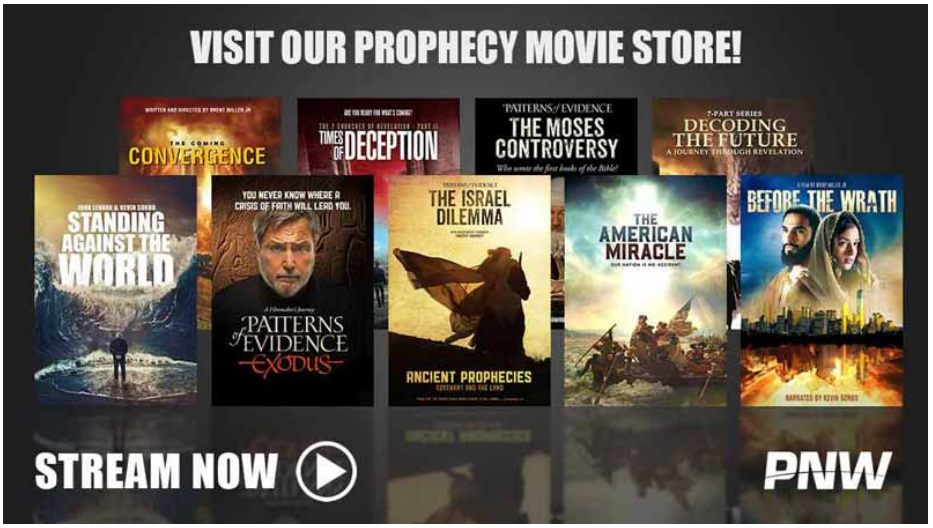
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ARTICLE

# The Battle For Israel Is Now Being Fought Inside The Church



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 23, 2026

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For decades, the battle over Israel has been fought in the halls of the United Nations, across university campuses, and in the streets of major cities. But an increasingly bitter confrontation is now unfolding in a place many Christians might never have expected: inside the Church itself.




At the heart of the dispute is a question that reaches far beyond Middle Eastern politics. Does the Jewish people's return to their ancient homeland represent the fulfillment of biblical promises, or has the coming of Jesus Christ changed how those promises should be understood?

The answer is dividing Christian denominations, challenging longstanding theological traditions, and raising fundamental questions about God's covenant with Israel.

Some church leaders are now openly condemning Christian Zionism as a dangerous ideology. Others insist that abandoning the biblical promises to Israel risks undermining the very foundation of God's faithfulness.

And the stakes go far beyond whether Christians support the modern State of Israel. The deeper issue is whether God's ancient promises to the Jewish people still stand.

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**When Christian Leaders Turn Against Zionism**

The controversy intensified when the Patriarchs and Heads of the Churches in Jerusalem issued a statement condemning what they called "damaging ideologies, such as Christian Zionism."

The declaration, supported by prominent Orthodox and Catholic church leaders in Jerusalem, warned against outside interference in the affairs of local Christian communities.

Their position reflects a longstanding tension between Christian Zionists, who view Jewish restoration to Israel as biblically significant, and many historic churches in the Middle East, whose members include Palestinian Christians living amid the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

But the opposition extends far beyond Jerusalem.

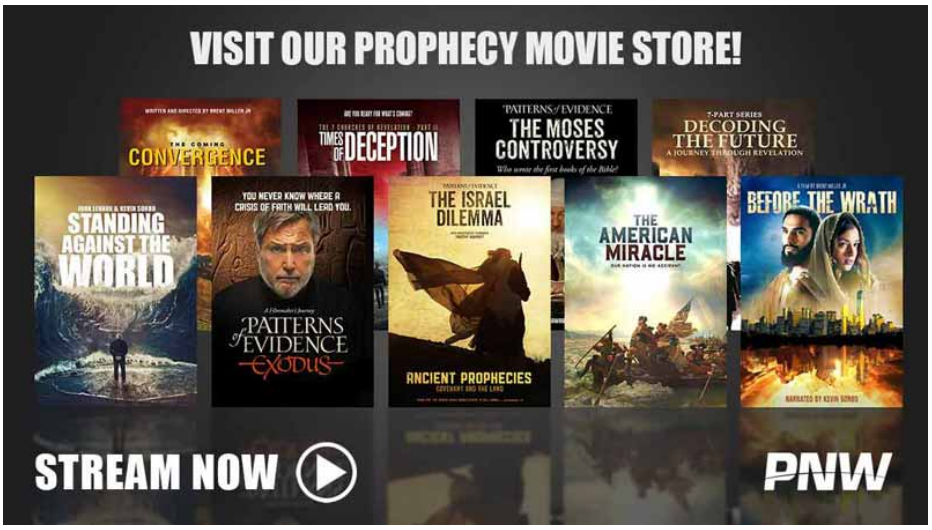
The Presbyterian Church (USA) has taken an increasingly confrontational position toward Christian Zionism, including a General Assembly resolution rejecting it and an August conference titled "Christianity Without Christian Zionism."

Other mainline Protestant denominations, including elements of the Methodist, Lutheran, Episcopal, and United Church of Christ traditions, have similarly challenged theological arguments used to support Israeli territorial claims.

The Catholic Church takes a different approach. While recognizing Israel's right to exist in security and affirming the enduring significance of the Jewish people, the Vatican does not teach that modern Israeli sovereignty or territorial boundaries are automatically guaranteed by biblical prophecy. It also advocates Palestinian national rights and a negotiated peace.

Eastern Orthodox churches generally interpret Israel's biblical promises through Christ and the Church rather than through the establishment of a modern nation-state.

These traditions do not all share identical positions. Opposition to Christian Zionism does not necessarily mean opposition to Jewish people or even to Israel's existence. Nevertheless, their disagreements with evangelical Christian Zionists reveal a profound theological divide.



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**Why Evangelicals Continue To Stand With Israel**

On the other side are millions of evangelical Christians, particularly within Baptist, Pentecostal, independent Bible church, and dispensational traditions, who believe the restoration of Israel is deeply connected to biblical prophecy.

For these believers, support for Israel is not simply a political preference or an expression of sympathy for Jewish suffering throughout history.

They believe God made specific promises to Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and their descendants concerning the land of Israel. Those promises, they argue, were never canceled, transferred entirely to the Church, or rendered meaningless by the coming of Christ.

The modern restoration of Jewish sovereignty in 1948, followed by Israel's dramatic territorial changes in 1967, is therefore viewed by many as prophetically significant.

Prominent evangelical supporters of Israel, including Pastor John Hagee and former Arkansas Governor and U.S. Ambassador to Israel Mike Huckabee, have defended the Jewish people's historic and biblical connection to the land.

Christians from several theological traditions affirm the continuing significance of God's covenant with Israel, even while disagreeing over prophetic timelines or the meaning of the modern state.

The central question remains: What did God actually promise, and did He ever revoke those promises?

**God's Covenant With Abraham Was Not Temporary**

The biblical argument begins in Genesis 12, where God calls Abraham and promises to make him a great nation.

God declares:

"I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed." (Genesis 12:3)

The promise contains both a universal blessing for the nations and a special covenant relationship with Abraham's descendants.

But Scripture goes further.

In Genesis 15:18, God establishes a covenant with Abraham concerning a specific geographical inheritance, describing land extending from the river of Egypt to the Euphrates.

In Genesis 17:7–8, God calls His covenant an "everlasting covenant" and describes Canaan as an "everlasting possession" for Abraham's descendants.

For Christian Zionists, these passages establish an important principle: God's promises were not merely symbolic expressions of spiritual blessing. They included a real people, a real land, and an enduring covenant.

This does not mean every action of the modern Israeli government carries divine approval. Israel's own prophets repeatedly condemned the nation's sins and warned of judgment.

But divine discipline and divine abandonment are not the same thing.

Indeed, the Old Testament repeatedly describes Israel's disobedience, exile, and eventual restoration as part of the same covenant story.

The question is not whether Israel has always been faithful to God. Scripture clearly says otherwise.

The question is whether God remains faithful to Israel despite its failures.

**Did God Promise To Bring Israel Back?**

The prophet Ezekiel describes a remarkable future restoration.

In Ezekiel 36:24, God declares:

"For I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land."

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The following chapter presents the famous vision of the valley of dry bones in which a seemingly lifeless nation is restored.

God identifies the bones as "the whole house of Israel" and promises to bring His people into the land of Israel.

Christian Zionists see these passages as particularly significant because they describe both a physical regathering and a subsequent spiritual transformation.

In Ezekiel 36, the return to the land is followed by God's promise to cleanse His people, give them a new heart, and place His Spirit within them.

This sequence is important to those who interpret modern Israel as an early stage of a larger prophetic restoration.

The Jewish state may exist today, they argue, without the Jewish nation having yet experienced the full spiritual renewal described by the prophets.

Critics interpret these prophecies differently, often emphasizing their fulfillment in the return from Babylonian exile, the coming of Christ, or the spiritual restoration of God's people.

But the specificity of Ezekiel's language presents a serious interpretive question: Why repeatedly describe the restoration of Israel to its own land if the ultimate promise has no continuing national dimension?

Jeremiah makes the issue even more striking.

In Jeremiah 31:35–37, God connects Israel's continued existence as a nation before Him to the established order of the sun, moon, and stars.

The imagery is extraordinary. Israel's continued identity is presented as something bound to the faithfulness of the Creator Himself.

For those who believe God's covenant promises remain in force, these passages are foundational.

**Has The Church Replaced Israel?**

Perhaps no New Testament passage addresses this controversy more directly than Romans 11.

The Apostle Paul begins with a question:

"Hath God cast away his people?"

His answer is immediate:

"God forbid." (Romans 11:1)

Paul then develops the image of an olive tree, explaining that Gentile believers have been grafted into a covenantal relationship rooted in God's promises.

But he warns them against arrogance toward the natural branches.

"Boast not against the branches," Paul writes in Romans 11:18.

He later declares that "the gifts and calling of God are without repentance" (Romans 11:29), meaning that God's calling is not something He simply withdraws.

For Christian Zionists, Romans 11 is among the clearest New Testament affirmations that God has not finished His purposes for the Jewish people.

Paul even speaks of a future in which "all Israel shall be saved," a passage that has generated centuries of theological discussion.

Those who reject a distinct national future for Israel point to other New Testament passages.

Galatians 3 emphasizes that those who belong to Christ are Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise. Ephesians 2 describes Jews and Gentiles becoming one new humanity in Christ. Hebrews points believers toward a heavenly homeland and the ultimate fulfillment of God's promises.

These passages are central to the argument that Christ transforms how the Old Testament covenants should be understood.

But Christian Zionists respond that the spiritual unity of Jews and Gentiles in Christ does not require the cancellation of God's specific promises to Israel.

In their understanding, the Church's participation in Abraham's spiritual blessings does not mean that the Jewish people's covenant identity has disappeared.

Paul's warning against Gentile arrogance makes that distinction especially important.

**Jerusalem, The Nations, And The Prophetic Future**

The prophet Zechariah describes a future in which people from many nations seek the God of Israel.

In Zechariah 8:23, ten men from the languages of the nations take hold of the garment of a Jewish man, declaring:

"We will go with you: for we have heard that God is with you."

It is a striking picture of the nations recognizing God's continuing work among the Jewish people.

Zechariah later describes Jerusalem as a focal point of international conflict and divine intervention, particularly in chapters 12–14.

Jesus Himself spoke of Jerusalem being trampled by the Gentiles "until the times of the Gentiles be fulfilled" (Luke 21:24).

For many evangelical believers, such passages reinforce the conviction that Jerusalem and Israel retain a meaningful place in God's future plans.

The Christian Zionist position is therefore not simply that Jews deserve a homeland because of historical persecution, although that history provides a powerful moral argument.

It is that Scripture describes a continuing divine purpose involving the Jewish people, their restoration, and Jerusalem itself.

**The Question The Church Cannot Avoid**

The modern dispute over Christian Zionism is about much more than diplomatic policy, territorial boundaries, or the actions of Israeli leaders.

It touches the reliability of God's promises, the relationship between Israel and the Church, and the interpretation of biblical prophecy.

Christians can disagree about particular Israeli policies, the treatment of Palestinians, and the best political path toward peace without abandoning serious theological engagement with Israel's place in Scripture.

But the underlying biblical questions cannot simply be dismissed as modern political ideology.

God's covenant with Abraham, Ezekiel's restoration prophecies, Jeremiah's promises, and Paul's unmistakable warning against Gentile arrogance all demand careful consideration.

And as churches increasingly take opposing positions on Christian Zionism, believers face a question that has echoed through centuries of Christian theology:

Has God finished His work with Israel, or does the Jewish nation still have a future in His unfolding plan?

For Christians who believe the covenant promises remain, the answer rests not on the shifting politics of the Middle East, but on the enduring faithfulness of the God who made those promises in the first place.

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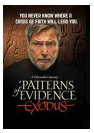

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